STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE			AU-13300
	SARPY COUNTY SHERIFF'S OFFICE PAPILLION * NEBRASKA **GREG LONDON** **SHERIFF**	DATE ISSUED **08/23/24**	DATE REVISED	DATE REVIEWED 02/02/25
		APPROVED: *GREG LONDON*		
CHAPTER TITLE AUXILIARY UNITS: DIGITAL FORENSICS UNIT		RESOURCES		
SUBJECT DIGITAL FORENSICS UNIT OPERATIONS AND TRAINING		CROSS REFERENCE		

I. Purpose:

The purpose of this policy is to establish guidelines for Digital Forensics Unit (DFU) operations during investigations and training.

II. Policy:

A. The DFU shall function under all policies and procedures established for the Sheriff's Office. The operations of the DFU, including training, shall be controlled by policy and procedure and shall be closely supervised by the DFU Commander.

B. The Digital Forensics Unit is established to provide specialized digital forensic services in support of criminal investigations conducted by the Sheriff's Office and other law enforcement agencies. The primary objective of the DFU is to extract, preserve, analyze, and present digital evidence in a forensically-sound manner, ensuring its admissibility in court proceedings. The DFU aims to enhance investigative outcomes, maintain the integrity of digital evidence, and contribute to the pursuit of justice.

III. Procedure:

A. Data Extraction in a Forensically-Sound Manner

1. The DFU shall employ industry-standard and legally accepted methods for data extraction, ensuring that all digital evidence is collected in a forensically-sound and legally defensible manner.

2. All data extraction activities shall adhere to established chain of custody procedures to maintain the integrity and traceability of digital evidence.

3. DFU personnel shall utilize specialized hardware and software tools designed for digital forensics to ensure the accuracy and completeness of data extraction.

4. The DFU shall document and record the process of data extraction, including the methodology, tools used, and any challenges encountered.

B. Digital Evidence Analysis

1. The DFU shall analyze digital evidence provided by the primary investigator with the utmost professionalism and expertise.

2. Analysis shall include but not be limited to recovering deleted files, examining digital communications, identifying relevant metadata, and decrypting protected data.

3. DFU analysts shall conduct comprehensive examinations, maintaining a focus on identifying pertinent information that could contribute to the investigation.

4. The DFU shall document analysis procedures, findings, and conclusions in a clear and concise manner, producing reports suitable for court presentation if required.

C. Request for DFU Services

1. Requests for DFU services shall be initiated by the primary investigator or a designated supervisor within the Sarpy County Sheriff's Office.

2. The request shall outline the scope and nature of the investigation, the type of digital evidence to be examined, and any specific requirements or deadlines.

3. The DFU shall prioritize requests based on the severity and urgency of the case, in consultation with the requesting investigator or supervisor.

D. Training and Professional Development

1. DFU personnel shall undergo regular training to stay current with advancements in digital forensics techniques, tools, and legal standards.

2. Training programs shall cover areas such as data recovery, mobile device forensics, network analysis, encryption technologies, and courtroom testimony.

3. The DFU shall encourage personnel to pursue relevant certifications and memberships in professional organizations to enhance their expertise.

4. Training records shall be maintained to track the ongoing professional development of DFU personnel.

E. Compliance and Oversight

1. The DFU shall operate in full compliance with local, state, and federal laws, as well as established policies and procedures of the Sarpy County Sheriff's Office.

2. The DFU's operations and practices may be subject to periodic internal audits and external reviews to ensure adherence to standards and best practices.

F. Confidentiality and Information Security

1. DFU personnel shall handle all digital evidence and related information in a confidential and secure manner.

2. Any information obtained during the course of digital evidence analysis shall be treated as sensitive and protected from unauthorized access.